Section 4: Leave and Absence

This section explains how much leave you are entitled to, how to request it and what happens when you are unable to work. It applies to all employees, whether full time or part time, from the first day of employment.

4.1 Annual leave

Entitlement

Your entitlement depends on your length of service on 1 January of the leave year. Part-time employees receive a pro-rata entitlement.

Length of service	Days per year	Maximum carry-over
Less than 2 years	25	5 days
2 to 4 years	27	5 days
5 to 9 years	29	7 days
10 years or more	31	10 days

How to request leave

Leave must be approved by your line manager before it is booked. Requests are made through the HR portal at least two weeks ahead. You can also use the command line tool:

```
hr-portal submit --form L-12 --from 2026-08-03 --to 2026-08-07
```

A request is approved only when you receive a confirmation e-mail. The following rules apply to all requests:

(a) No more than ten consecutive working days may be taken without the written agreement of a director.

(b) Leave over the year end is handled as follows:

  (i) days carried over must be taken by 31 March;

  (ii) days not taken by that date lapse without payment.

(c) Teams must agree cover for client work before leave starts.

Peak periods

Quarter-end and the two weeks before a major client deadline are treated as peak periods. During a peak period no more than one person from each team may be on leave at the same time. Directors publish the peak calendar in November for the following year, and requests made before then are accepted on a first come, first served basis.

Leaving the company

On the last day of employment, any untaken leave is paid at the normal daily rate. If you have taken more leave than you have earned, the difference is deducted from your final pay.

4.2 Public holidays

The office is closed on the public holidays below. Staff who are required to work on a public holiday receive a day in lieu.

Date	Day	Holiday
1 January	Thursday	New Year’s Day
3 April	Friday	Good Friday

Date	Day	Holiday
6 April	Monday	Easter Monday
4 May	Monday	Early May bank holiday
25 May	Monday	Spring bank holiday
31 August	Monday	Summer bank holiday
25 December	Friday	Christmas Day
28 December	Monday	Boxing Day (substitute day)

4.3 Sickness absence

If you are unwell you must tell your line manager before your normal starting time on the first day of absence. Sick pay is paid in full for the first 26 weeks in any rolling twelve months.

1) Telephone your line manager; a message left with a colleague is not enough.
2) Keep the manager informed every three days if the absence continues.
3) Send a medical note to HR from the eighth calendar day.

Return-to-work conversations are held after every period of absence of five days or more.

4.4 Types of leave at a glance

Type of leave	Who approves	Notice required	Paid?
Annual leave	Line manager	Two weeks	Yes
Sick leave, up to 7 days	Not required; self-certification	On the first day	Yes
Sick leave, over 7 days	HR, with a medical note	On the first day	Yes, see 4.3
Compassionate leave	Line manager	As soon as possible	Yes, up to 5 days
Jury service	HR	On receipt of the summons	Yes, less any allowance
Medical appointments	Line manager	One week where possible	Yes, up to 4 hours
Study leave	Director	One month	Yes, up to 10 days per year
Volunteering day	Line manager	Two weeks	Yes, one day per year
Parental leave	HR	Eight weeks	As set out in section 5
Adoption leave	HR	Eight weeks	As set out in section 5
Unpaid leave	Director	One month	No
Sabbatical, after 7 years	Board	Six months	Half pay for up to 3 months
Military reserve training	HR	On receipt of the call-up	Yes, for up to 2 weeks
Religious observance	Line manager	One week	Taken from annual leave
Emergency dependants' leave	Line manager	As soon as possible	Yes, up to 2 days
Marriage or civil partnership	Line manager	Four weeks	Yes, 2 days
House move	Line manager	One week	Yes, 1 day
Public office	Director	One month	No
Professional examinations	Line manager	One month	Yes, examination days only
Blood donation	Line manager	One week	Yes, half a day

Type of leave	Who approves	Notice required	Paid?
Training courses	Line manager	Two weeks	Yes
Trade union duties	HR	One week	Yes, reasonable time
Fertility treatment	Line manager	One week	Yes, appointments only
Day in lieu	Line manager	One week	Yes
Career break	Board	Six months	No

4.5 Contact

Questions about this section should be sent to the People team, who will reply within two working days.